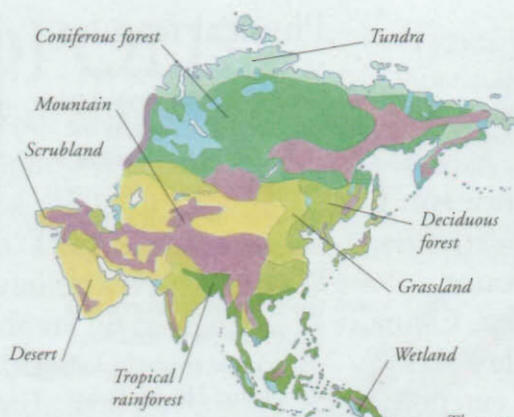


Climatic zones

Asia has every kind of climate and landscape. In the far north, Siberia is covered in tundra, where part of the ground is permanently frozen. South of the tundra are coniferous forests and open grasslands (steppes). Central and southwest Asia are mostly desert and mountains, while the east has deciduous forests. Tropical rainforests cover much of the south and southeast.



Tundra

In the bitterly cold and treeless tundra region of Siberia, the subsoil remains frozen – a condition known as permafrost. With temperatures of less than -10°C (14°F) and covered by snow for six to ten months of the year, the topsoil thaws only briefly in the summer. The tundra has rich mineral resources.

Mosses, lichens, and a few flowers appear briefly during the warmer months.

The steppes are the Asian equivalent of the pampas and prairies of the Americas.



Taiga

The Siberian taiga, which lies to the south of the tundra, is the world's largest coniferous forest. The main trees are spruce, fir, larch, and pine. In the spring, much of the taiga becomes flooded as the lower reaches of the north-flowing rivers thaw, while their mouths remain frozen. In summer, some ground remains swampy; in winter it freezes.



Steppes

The wide, open grasslands that cover Mongolia and southern Siberia are known as the steppes. Livestock is grazed on these broad, treeless plains, which, in places, merge into semi-desert. The soil is mostly fertile and, with irrigation, many areas have become productive farmland.

Harsh conditions make trees stunted and sparse. Ice and snow cover the region for half the year.

Dunes form as sand drifts in the prevailing wind.

Taklimakan Desert, China



Deserts

Asia has both hot and cold deserts, as well as many regions of semi-desert where animals can be grazed. Middle Eastern deserts are hot and dry all year, with cold nights. The Gobi and Taklimakan deserts of Central Asia have scorching summers, but are bitterly cold in winter.



Mangrove roots help stop coast eroding in storms.

Wetlands

Mangrove swamps are found along many coasts of southern Asia, from India to the Philippines. The mangrove trees have long, spreading roots, producing a forest that looks as if it is on stilts. Logging and pollution are destroying many mangroves.

Temperatures average 21°C (70°F), with 2,000 mm (79 in) of rain per year.



Tropical rainforest

There are tropical rainforests in India, Southeast Asia, and the Philippines. They flourish on the southern slopes of the Himalayas, and in Burma (Myanmar), the Malay Peninsula, and the western part of the island of Irian Jaya. Home to 40 per cent of all plant and animal species, the world's rainforests are threatened, as people cut down trees for the timber industry and to clear space for farming.

Trees lose their leaves in winter as a means of protecting themselves from wind and cold.



Deciduous forest

Asia has comparatively few broadleaf forests of deciduous trees that shed their leaves in winter. They occur mainly in eastern Asia, including China, Japan, and the Koreans, or in cooler upland areas, such as the mountains of Nepal.

People

Asia contains two-thirds of the world's population, and the birth rate is still rising in many countries. Most people live in the southern and eastern regions and in the fertile river valleys. Many are farmers, although increasing numbers are moving into expanding cities in search of work.



Israeli boy Vietnamese girl Japanese boy

Resources

Asia's natural resources include farmland, which provides work for 60 per cent of the people, and the fishing grounds of the Pacific Ocean. Minerals include oil and natural gas from the Gulf States, as well as bauxite, copper, coal, diamonds, gold, iron, lead, manganese, mercury, tin, and titanium.



Tuna fish